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How to memorize a song on *guitar.*

Close the page sooner than feels comfortable, learn the map before the notes, and drill the seams between sections rather than the sections themselves.

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Memorize a song on guitar by learning its form before its notes, working in named chunks of four to eight bars, drilling the joins between those chunks as items in their own right, and testing recall cold the next day with the tab out of sight. Reading the tab again is the one thing that feels like memorizing and is not: while the page is open it does the remembering for you. Memory is built at the moment you do not know what comes next and have to produce it anyway, and every glance at the page skips that moment.

Why reading the tab on repeat does not stick

Playing from tab and playing from memory are different skills. With the page open you are converting symbols into motions in real time. Take it away and you have to produce the next bar with no prompt. The two feel similar while you do them, which is why a player can run a song many times off the page and still be lost the first time it is closed.

Recognition is cheap, and it feels exactly like knowing. Retrieval is the expensive version, and the only way to train it is to attempt it and be wrong sometimes. The pause where you cannot find the next chord is the repetition that counts.

So remove the cue earlier than is comfortable. Put the tablet face down or the sheet on the floor, because anything inside your eye-line gets used without a decision. Then withdraw the support in steps:

- Full tab or notation, where you start.
- Chord and section names only, on one line of paper.
- Section names only, in order, nothing about the notes.
- Nothing on the stand at all.

Playing along with the recording is the same crutch in audio form: it tells you what is coming and holds the tempo. Learn the song silent, then put the record on to find out whether you were right.

Finger memory and knowing the form are two different things

When a song falls apart from memory it is usually the map that went rather than the notes, and the two fail in different ways.

Finger memory

Finger memory is a chain of motions, each one cued by the movement before it: fast, automatic, and needing no attention. It is brittle in one way. Break the chain and there is no obvious way back in, which is why one wrong chord can take the next thirty seconds of a part you have played hundreds of times.

The form

The form is the map you can say out loud away from the instrument: which sections exist, in what order, how many times each repeats, and how it ends. It is slower than finger memory, and it is what lets you re-enter after a break. Someone who knows the form can be lost for two bars and still arrive at the top of the chorus on time.

Write it on one line, with bar counts:

Intro 4 | Verse 16 | Chorus 8 | Verse 16 | Chorus 8 | Solo 16 |
Chorus 8 | Chorus 8 | Outro 4

The repeat counts are worth being pedantic about. The thing that ends a song you would say you know is rarely a wrong note. It is one chorus too many, or leaving the second verse eight bars early because it felt like the first. Next to each change, note the cue that announces it: a drum fill, a word in the lyric, a chord that appears nowhere else. Where you hesitate saying the line out loud is where you will hesitate playing it.

The song readiness score keeps this as a check of its own, separate from anything about your hands. Reading the form and knowing it feel identical while the page is open.

Chunk by section, not by however far you got

A chunk is a complete musical unit with a beginning and an end, usually four to eight bars. Not five minutes of work, and not the stretch you reached before you got bored. Give each chunk a name you would use out loud, and use the same names every session.

- **Two or three chunks per session, at most.** A chunk is done for the day once you can play it twice, cold, with nothing on the stand. More repetitions that afternoon measure how long you can hold something in the front of your mind.
- **Stop starting at the top.** Bar one every time gives the intro a repetition on every pass and the last section almost none. The intro of a half-learned song is always its strongest part, which tells you about the rehearsal order, not the song.

- **Learn it backwards.** Take the final chunk first, then add the one before it and play to the end. Every pass finishes on familiar ground, and endings stop being the part you have played twice.
- **Separate technical trouble from memory trouble.** A section that fails because it is hard is not a memory job. Take it out and repair it, which is what the four-stage loop is for, then bring it back.

The joins are the song

The experience that sends people back to the tab: every section is fine on its own, and the song still stops. A section drilled in isolation comes with its own run-up. You knew it was coming, your hand was in position, the tempo was set. In the song it arrives cold, out of whatever the previous bar left behind.

So list the joins and practice those instead. Six sections gives five joins, plus one more for every repeat, and a chorus into a second chorus is its own item because the exit is different. That list is where the song breaks.

- **Shrink the join to two bars.** The last bar of one section and the first bar of the next. Loop it until the change is boring rather than occasionally correct.
- **Then widen to four.** Two bars either side, so approach and landing are both in the loop.
- **Chain forward one link at a time.** First into second, second into third, then first into second into third.
- **Give each join a cue.** The join is where you consult the map, so it needs something to consult: a lyric, a fill, a bass note, a hand shape.

If a join fails for physical reasons rather than memory ones, the fix is speed rather than repetition. The [tempo ladder builder](#) turns one change into a starting speed, a target and the steps between, and Strumly covers what to change with your hands in its guide to [smoother chord transitions](#).

The cold-start test

A cold start is the first thing you do with the guitar that day: no warm-up, no run-up, no page, no backing track. Pick it up, name a section, and play from there. One attempt, because the second is a different and much easier test.

Run it the next day rather than the same session. Inside a session you are partly holding the song in the front of your mind, and that version evaporates overnight. It is also the honest question, because the moments when somebody asks you to play do not come with a warm-up.

The test gets harder in a fixed order:

1. Start at the top, cold, and get to the end without stopping.
2. Start from a middle section you choose, cold, with no run-up.
3. Have somebody else name the section, so you cannot pick a favorite.

Score it pass or fail and write down where it came apart. Being able to start only from bar one is a diagnosis rather than a general weakness: the song is one long chain instead of a set of parts you know. The [readiness checklist](#) scores cold starts alongside nine other checks and hands back the single heaviest one you have not passed.

Recover mid-song instead of restarting

Stopping at a mistake is a rehearsed skill like any other. If every repetition ends where the error is, the error is the ending you have practiced most. That is how a player arrives at playing for somebody with the first eight bars solid, the last eight barely known, and a reflex to stop the moment a chord goes wrong.

Recovery is not playing without mistakes. It is keeping time while your hands are wrong and re-entering at the next landmark. Two rules, both decided before the take.

- **Protect the beat, not the notes.** Strumming muted strings in time for two bars is a recovery. A silence while you find the shape is a breakdown, and more audible than the chord that caused it.
- **Aim at the next landmark.** The downbeat of the next bar if you can reach it, the top of the next section if you cannot. Going back to repair the note you dropped costs the four bars after it as well.

Practice it directly, because it will not turn up on its own: play the song through and fumble one chord on purpose while the strumming hand keeps moving. It feels ridiculous, which is the point. You are training the response, not the mistake.

How to keep a song once you have it

Songs decay in a predictable order. The riff comes back quickly and the form goes first: section order, repeat counts, ending. A song learned in spring and untouched since midsummer is usually not lost. Its map has gone while the motions stayed.

Maintenance is therefore a cold take rather than a rehearsal. One pass, nothing on the stand, no restarts, early in the session, and then you stop whether or not it was any good. Running it again turns maintenance back into practice.

- **Keep a written list** of every song you would claim to know. Your memory of what you can play is as unreliable as your memory of the songs.
- **Rotate by neglect.** Two or three a session, chosen because you have not touched them in longest, not because they are the ones you enjoy.
- **Refresh the map, not the notes.** Every few weeks, say the form out loud away from the guitar. A minute per song, and it catches the thing that actually goes.
- **Repair the chunk, not the song.** When a maintenance take fails, fix the chunk or the join that broke. Relearning the whole thing is the expensive way to fix eight bars.

Where this sits in a week is a scheduling question. The [intermediate practice routine](#) gives repertoire under pressure and the cold-start test blocks of their own, and Strumly's guide to [designing a practice routine](#) covers building the week around them.

What to do this week

1. Write the form of one song on a single line, with bar counts and the cue for each change. Say it out loud with the guitar down.
2. List the joins, and loop the two worst as two-bar fragments.
3. Tomorrow, pick the guitar up first thing and start from a middle section, cold, with nothing on the stand. Write down what happened.
4. Play one take with a deliberate fumble in it, keeping the beat straight through the mistake.

None of that makes the song feel finished faster. It makes the point at which you can say you know it something you can check: page closed, on a day you did not warm up.

GuitarHub Field Guide No. 10. The latest version of this guide, with its tools and links, lives at guitarhub.org/how-to-memorize-songs-on-guitar.

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